The Course of the Great War (1914–1918)

LITERARY READING EXTRACTS, HISTORICAL ENQUIRY & SPACED RETRIEVAL HOMEWORK COMPANION

Scholar Name: _____ **Form:** _____ **Teacher:** _____ **Year:** _____



The Menin Road (1919) by Paul Nash • Imperial War Museums (ART 2242). Commissioned by the British War Memorials Committee, this iconic modernist masterpiece captures the apocalyptic devastation of the Ypres Salient, echoing the wartime memoirs of Siegfried Sassoon and Ernst Jünger.

ENQUIRY / HISTORICAL FOCUS	TASK A: READ-ALOUD	TASK B: QUIZ	MILESTONE	PARENT SIGN & DATE
Enquiry 1: 1914 & Colours	[ ] Read Aloud	[/ 6]	[ ] Br [ ] Sil [ ] Gld	_____
Enquiry 2: Trenches & Haig	[ ] Read Aloud	[/ 6]	[ ] Br [ ] Sil [ ] Gld	_____
Enquiry 3: Global Empire Fronts	[ ] Read Aloud	[/ 6]	[ ] Br [ ] Sil [ ] Gld	_____
Enquiry 4: Home Front & Women	[ ] Read Aloud	[/ 6]	[ ] Br [ ] Sil [ ] Gld	_____
Enquiry 5: Versailles & Flawed Peace	[ ] Read Aloud	[/ 6]	[ ] Br [ ] Sil [ ] Gld	_____

WEEKLY HOMEWORK PROTOCOL (PARENT & SCHOLAR PARTNERSHIP):

1. DISCIPLINARY READING:
Read the left-hand literary extract aloud to a parent or learning partner with fluency and expression.

2. ORAL DISCUSSION:
Discuss the targeted hinge question together. Parent initials the reading sign-off box.

3. ACTIVE RETRIEVAL QUIZ:
Scholar completes the 6-question quiz in black ink from memory (strictly no notes or peeking).

4. SELF-CHECKING:
Scan the back cover QR code to self-check answers, record score out of 6, and obtain parent sign-off.

UNIT DIGITAL HUB
QUIZZES & LESSONS

Memoirs of an Infantry Officer

By Siegfried Sassoon • Captain, Royal Welch Fusiliers & War Poet (MC)

FRONTLINE WAR MEMOIR (1914)



Captain Siegfried Sassoon CBE MC, Royal Welch Fusiliers. Decorated frontline officer and war poet.

AUTHOR CONTEXT & HISTORICAL BACKGROUND:

Siegfried Sassoon was an English poet and officer in the Royal Welch Fusiliers awarded the Military Cross for bravery. In his celebrated wartime memoirs, he records the naive, sporting enthusiasm with which young British men volunteered in August 1914 and the sudden, chilling encounter with the realities of the casualty lists.

SCAN FOR AUDIO READ-ALOUD (SEND)

I was sitting in the pavilion at the village cricket ground on an idyllic August afternoon when the extraordinary news arrived... To me, as an irresponsible young gentleman with nothing better to do than hunt foxes and score occasional runs, the sudden prospect of European war seemed like a grand adventure, a chivalric crusade that had arrived just in time to rescue our generation from the dull routine of modern peacetime.

Everyone around me was swept along by the same strange fever. In the market towns and city recruiting stations, young clerks, schoolboys, shop assistants, and farm labourers queued for hours in the stifling August heat. Brass bands marched through the high streets playing patriotic anthems, church bells rang, and proud mothers pinned ribbons to their sons' lapels. We were assured by politicians and newspapers that the conflict would be settled within six months, that the Kaiser would be humbled, and that we should all return home before Christmas crowned with laurels of victory.

...It was only later, when the transport trains rolled into midnight stations and the first battalion casualty lists appeared in the Times, that the terrible silence descended. The names of boys I had played cricket against at school and shared benches with at university were printed row upon row in tiny black letters, grouped under the brutal heading: "Killed in Action." The heroic romance had vanished in an instant; the chivalric tournament was an illusion. We were not entering an adventure—we were being fed into an unrelenting industrial factory of death.

VOCABULARY VAULT (KEY TERMINOLOGY):

Chivalry: The medieval knightly code of honour, bravery, and self-sacrifice.
Laurels: A traditional Roman symbol of military victory and triumphant return.
Battalion: A military unit of roughly 1,000 frontline soldiers.

PARENT & SCHOLAR ORAL DISCUSSION GUIDE:

Think: What metaphor does Sassoon use at the end to describe what the war truly became? Contrast Sassoon's initial excitement at the cricket ground with his horror upon reading the casualty lists.

[ ] Oral Reading Verification: Scholar read extract aloud with expression & accuracy **Parent Initial:** _____ **Date:** _____

Enquiry Retrieval Quiz: Complete in black ink from memory. Do not peek at notes. Milestones: Q1–2 Bronze • Q3–4 Silver • Q5–6 Gold

1. ► Who appeared on famous recruitment posters pointing his finger with the slogan "Your Country Needs You"?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

2. ► What was the nickname given to battalions of friends, workmates, and neighbours who enlisted together in 1914?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

3. ►► Why did hundreds of thousands of young British men rush to enlist in August and September 1914?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

4. ►► What symbol of cowardice was publicly handed to young men in civilian clothes on British streets?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

5. ►►► Why did the concept of "Pals Battalions" ultimately prove to be a catastrophic social tragedy?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

6. ►►► How did the transition from a small professional army to a mass citizen army transform British society?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

KEY TERM VAULT: Lord Kitchener | Pals Battalions | White Feather | Propaganda | Over by Christmas | BEF (120,000)

Score: [/ 6]

Storm of Steel

By Ernst Jünger • Frontline Officer, German 73rd Hanoverian Regiment (Pour le Mérite)

EYEWITNESS COMBAT MEMOIR (1915–1916)



Soldiers standing in waterlogged mud in a frontline trench on the Western Front • Imperial War Museums (IWM Q 51551).

AUTHOR CONTEXT & HISTORICAL BACKGROUND:

Ernst Jünger was a German frontline officer wounded fourteen times who fought continuously on the Western Front from 1914 to 1918. His 1920 memoir Storm of Steel (In Stahlgewittern) provides an astonishing, unromanticized German eyewitness account of technological industrial bombardment in the trenches.

SCAN FOR AUDIO READ-ALOUD (SEND)

The earth shook, the sky was a raging cauldron of black smoke and blinding fire, and the deafening roar of the heavy artillery stunned our senses until conscious thought itself became impossible. We huddled packed together in deep subterranean dugouts carved thirty feet into the damp chalk, listening with racing hearts to the relentless pounding of the high-explosive shells detonating overhead. Every direct hit sent shockwaves rippling through the rock, extinguishing our candles and showering our steel helmets in suffocating chalk dust.

When the bombardment finally lifted, we scrambled up the shattered steps into the daylight. The trench was no longer a trench; it had been violently obliterated into a chaotic lunar wilderness of craters filled with foul stagnant water, tangled coils of severed barbed wire, and unburied corpses. Machine guns from the opposing ridges swept the ruined parapet with rapid metallic chatter, spraying deadly streams of lead that cut down any soldier who dared raise his head even an inch above the rim.

...In this monstrous landscape of pulverized chalk and iron, individual human courage counted for almost nothing against the mechanical supremacy of modern industrial war. The machine gunner did not need personal bravery or martial skill; he merely depressed the cold firing button to mow down an entire advancing company in minutes. It was no longer a contest of man against man, but the brutal annihilation of fragile human flesh by unfeeling machinery.

VOCABULARY VAULT (KEY TERMINOLOGY):

Artillery: Large-calibre heavy guns capable of firing explosive shells over long distances.
Traverse: A bank of earth or sandbags built across a trench to contain blast shockwaves.
Attrition: Wearing down enemy strength and manpower through continuous losses.

PARENT & SCHOLAR ORAL DISCUSSION GUIDE:

Think: Why does Jünger conclude that individual human courage counted for almost nothing in the trenches? Discuss whether British or German soldiers faced identical horrors in No Man's Land.

[ ] Oral Reading Verification: Scholar read extract aloud with expression & accuracy **Parent Initial:** _____ **Date:** _____

Enquiry Retrieval Quiz: Complete in black ink from memory. Do not peek at notes. Milestones: Q1–2 Bronze • Q3–4 Silver • Q5–6 Gold

7. ► Which weapon was responsible for approximately 60% of all combat casualties on the Western Front?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

8. ► What painful medical condition was caused by soldiers standing in cold, waterlogged mud for days?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

9. ►► Why were frontline trenches constructed in a zig-zag or traverse pattern rather than straight lines?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

10. ►► Why did the week-long British artillery bombardment fail to destroy German defenses before the Somme in 1916?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

11. ►►► Why is Field Marshal Sir Douglas Haig remembered both as the "Butcher of the Somme" and the architect of victory?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

12. ►►► How did the development of tanks and creeping barrages eventually break the trench deadlock in 1918?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

KEY TERM VAULT: No Man's Land | Trench Foot | Heavy Artillery | Sir Douglas Haig | The Somme (1916) | Combined Arms

Score: [/ 6]

Indian Voices of the Great War: Soldiers' Letters

By David Omissi (ed.) & Sepoys of the Indian Army • Frontline Sepoys & Sowars, Indian Expeditionary Force

FRONTLINE SOLDIERS' LETTERS (1914–1918)



Sikh machine gunners and Indian Army troops on the Western Front, 1915.

AUTHOR CONTEXT & HISTORICAL BACKGROUND:

Over 1.3 million Indian soldiers and personnel served in the British Indian Army across Europe, the Middle East, and Africa. Their letters home, censored by British military authorities, reveal the shock of industrial warfare in the freezing mud of Flanders and their pride in defending their regiment's honour.

SCAN FOR AUDIO READ-ALOUD (SEND)

The fighting in this foreign land is beyond human description. Do not think, my brothers, that this war is like any conflict we have heard of in old times or read of in ancient poems. It is not war; it is a mechanical monster that eats living men. The cannon fire never ceases for a single hour, day or night. Shrapnel bursts overhead like thunder, raining jagged iron from the sky, while machine-gun bullets hiss past our ears like venomous serpents.

We are stationed in frontline trenches where freezing mud reaches our waists, and the bitter European winter cuts through our woollen coats like sharpened knives. Many of our fellow sepoys have fallen sick with pneumonia and the agony of frostbite, their feet swollen and blackened by the damp. We were brought across the black water from the warm sun of Hindustan into this frozen slaughterhouse. Yet despite the cold and the terror, our regiments stand firm like iron walls, determined to preserve the honour and izzat of our ancestors, refusing to yield a single foot of ground to the enemy.

...Write to our village and tell my dear mother not to grieve if I do not return to her embrace. A warrior who dies fighting bravely on the battlefield achieves everlasting honour in both worlds. But I implore you, tell my younger brothers to remain behind in the village to plow the fields and tend the cattle; one son sacrificed to this terrible European fire is more than enough for our household.

VOCABULARY VAULT (KEY TERMINOLOGY):

Sepoy: An Indian frontline soldier serving in the British Indian Army.
Shrapnel: Small metal balls packed in artillery shells, sprayed upon detonation.
Frostbite: Tissue injury caused by extreme exposure to damp cold conditions.

PARENT & SCHOLAR ORAL DISCUSSION GUIDE:

Think: What does the Indian soldier mean when he calls the war 'a monster that eats men'? Discuss why colonial soldiers fought with such dedication thousands of miles from home.

[ ] Oral Reading Verification: Scholar read extract aloud with expression & accuracy **Parent Initial:** _____ **Date:** _____

Enquiry Retrieval Quiz: Complete in black ink from memory. Do not peek at notes. Milestones: Q1–2 Bronze • Q3–4 Silver • Q5–6 Gold

13. ► Approximately how many Indian soldiers and labourers served the British Empire during the Great War?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

14. ► What acronym was given to the Australian and New Zealand Army Corps who landed at Gallipoli in 1915?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

15. ►► What strategic objective did Winston Churchill hope to achieve by attacking the Ottoman Empire at Gallipoli in 1915?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

16. ►► Why were soldiers of the British West Indies Regiment often denied front-line combat roles?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

17. ►►► Why was the global contribution of colonial and African troops largely erased from popular British memory after 1918?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

18. ►►► How did participation in the Great War accelerate demands for national independence across the British Empire?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

KEY TERM VAULT: Indian Army (1.3M) | ANZAC | Gallipoli (1915) | British West Indies Regt | Labour Corps | East Africa Campaign

Score: [/ 6]

Testament of Youth

By Vera Brittain • Voluntary Aid Detachment (VAD) Nurse & Author

WARTIME AUTOBIOGRAPHY & NURSE MEMOIR (1915–1918)



Vera Brittain in her Voluntary Aid Detachment (VAD) uniform, 1915.

AUTHOR CONTEXT & HISTORICAL BACKGROUND:
Vera Brittain postponed her Oxford studies to volunteer as a VAD nurse, treating wounded British and German soldiers in London, Malta, and France. Having lost her fiancé, brother, and closest friends, her 1933 autobiography became the defining voice of the 'Lost Generation' of women.

SCAN FOR AUDIO READ-ALOUD (SEND)

The midnight hospital trains arrived in continuous succession, unloading hundreds of shattered, broken young men fresh from the slaughter of the Somme. Their khaki uniforms were caked in hardened trench clay, their eyes hollow with the haunting, unseeing stare of severe shell shock. Many lay motionless on stretchers along the cold corridors, unable to speak, their youth extinguished in a matter of hours by weapons their Victorian fathers could never have imagined.

In the surgical wards, we dressed wounds that made the heart turn cold—gangrenous limbs smelling of decay, agonizing chlorine gas burns that had stripped the delicate lining from human lungs, and faces torn away by jagged shards of flying shrapnel. We worked eighteen hours without respite, our aprons soaked with iodine and blood, our hands raw from carbolic acid, holding the trembling hands of dying eighteen-year-old boys who in their delirium mistook us for their mothers or sisters waiting at home.

...Meanwhile, across Britain, women were stepping forward to sustain the entire nation. We were driving omnibuses through darkened city streets, tilling the heavy soil in the Women's Land Army, and handling toxic cordite powder in explosive munitions factories. In the shell-filling plants, women's skin and hair turned bright yellow from toxic chemical exposure, earning them the nickname "Canary Girls." We proved beyond all doubt that women could carry the weight of an industrial empire in crisis. Yet as the casualty telegrams mounted daily, we realized with mounting grief that our reward would be mourning an entire generation of men who would never return to build a peacetime world.

VOCABULARY VAULT (KEY TERMINOLOGY):

VAD: Voluntary Aid Detachment: civilian volunteers providing nursing and medical care.
Shell Shock: Severe psychological trauma induced by prolonged artillery bombardment.
Canary Girls: Female munitions workers whose skin was stained yellow by toxic TNT chemicals.

PARENT & SCHOLAR ORAL DISCUSSION GUIDE:

Think: How did women's wartime experiences challenge Victorian stereotypes about women being frail? Discuss whether the 1918 vote for women over 30 was a fair reward for women's wartime sacrifices.

[ ] Oral Reading Verification: Scholar read extract aloud with expression & accuracy **Parent Initial:** _____ **Date:** _____

Enquiry Retrieval Quiz: Complete in black ink from memory. Do not peek at notes. Milestones: Q1–2 Bronze • Q3–4 Silver • Q5–6 Gold

19. ► What landmark law passed in August 1914 gave the British government sweeping emergency powers over daily life?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

20. ► What nickname was given to female munitions workers whose skin turned yellow from handling toxic TNT chemicals?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

21. ►► Why was compulsory conscription introduced for unmarried British men aged 18 to 41 in January 1916?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

22. ►► Why did the British government introduce compulsory food rationing for sugar, butter, and meat in early 1918?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

23. ►►► How did women's wartime work permanently shatter traditional Victorian gender stereotypes?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

24. ►►► To what extent did women's war work directly lead to women gaining the parliamentary vote in 1918?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

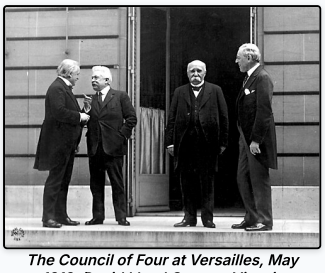
KEY TERM VAULT: DORA (1914) | Munitionettes | Canary Girls | Rationing (1918) | Conscription (1916) | 1918 Representation Act

Score: [/ 6]

The Economic Consequences of the Peace

By John Maynard Keynes • British Treasury Delegate to the 1919 Paris Peace Conference

POLITICAL & ECONOMIC EYEWITNESS ANALYSIS (1919)



The Council of Four at Versailles, May 1919: David Lloyd George, Vittorio Orlando, Georges Clemenceau, and Woodrow Wilson.

AUTHOR CONTEXT & HISTORICAL BACKGROUND:
John Maynard Keynes was a brilliant British Treasury economist who attended the 1919 Paris Peace Conference. Disgusted by the vindictive terms imposed on Germany, he resigned in protest and published this book warning that crushing the German economy would lead to economic catastrophe and future war.

SCAN FOR AUDIO READ-ALOUD (SEND)

The Council of Four assembled in the glittering Hall of Mirrors at Versailles, surrounded by gold and glass, but they were blind to the economic realities of the desperate continent they presumed to govern. Georges Clemenceau sat with his gloved hands folded across his chest, burning with an unrelenting desire to crush Germany permanently so that France might never again be invaded. Lloyd George pursued the fleeting demands of British electoral politics, promising angry voters that he would "squeeze the German lemon until the pips squeak." And President Woodrow Wilson, armed with noble principles of self-determination, proved tragically incapable of mastering the practical European negotiations.

Together, they drafted an ultimatum that treated Germany as a moral outlaw, compelling her delegates to sign Article 231—the War Guilt clause—under the imminent threat of renewed Allied invasion and starvation naval blockade. They demanded astronomical reparations running into billions of pounds, stripped the defeated nation of her merchant fleet, coalfields, and iron ore, yet demanded that she somehow generate vast surpluses of gold to pay her victors.

...I believe that the campaign for securing out of Germany the general costs of the war was one of the most serious acts of political unwisdom for which European statesmen have ever been responsible. If we aim deliberately at the impoverishment of Central Europe, vengeance, I dare predict, will not limp. By reducing seventy million people to perpetual poverty and humiliation, we are sowing dragon's teeth across the soil of Europe. Nothing can then delay that final civil war between the despairing forces of Reaction and Revolution, before which the horrors of the late German war will pale into insignificance.

VOCABULARY VAULT (KEY TERMINOLOGY):

Council of Four: The Allied leaders of Britain, France, the USA, and Italy at Versailles.
Article 231: The War Guilt clause forcing Germany to accept sole moral blame for the war.
Reparations: Compulsory financial payments demanded from Germany to cover Allied damages.

PARENT & SCHOLAR ORAL DISCUSSION GUIDE:

Think: What dark prophecy does Keynes make in his final sentence? Discuss whether the Treaty of Versailles was too harsh, or if the Allies failed because they refused to enforce it later.

[ ] Oral Reading Verification: Scholar read extract aloud with expression & accuracy **Parent Initial:** _____ **Date:** _____

Enquiry Retrieval Quiz: Complete in black ink from memory. Do not peek at notes. Milestones: Q1–2 Bronze • Q3–4 Silver • Q5–6 Gold

25. ► In what famous hall was the Treaty of Versailles signed on 28 June 1919, exactly five years after the assassination at Sarajevo?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

26. ► What controversial clause in the Treaty of Versailles (Article 231) forced Germany to accept sole moral blame for causing the war?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

27. ►► What staggering sum of financial reparations did the Inter-Allied Reparations Commission set for Germany to pay in 1921?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

28. ►► Why did German politicians and the public universally denounce the Treaty of Versailles as an unfair "Diktat"?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

29. ►►► How did the military restrictions of Versailles aim to prevent Germany from ever launching an offensive war again?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

30. ►►► Why did British political cartoonist Will Dyson portray a weeping toddler labeled "1940 Class" outside the Versailles peace conference?

Fact: _____

Explanation: _____

KEY TERM VAULT: Article 231 (War Guilt) | £6.6 Billion Reparations | Big Three | Diktat | Rhineland Demilitarisation | Keynes & Carthaginian Peace

Score: [/ 6]

SCAN TO SELF-CHECK DEPARTMENT ANSWERS

Digital Department Marking Bank & Model Explanations

Scan the QR code to check your retrieval quiz answers, read model historical mechanisms, and log your final scores online.

Why are answers not printed in this companion? *Cognitive science proves that effortful retrieval from memory produces dramatically stronger long-term schema retention than passive reading. Removing printed answer keys guarantees active recall and honest self-assessment at home.*

KS3 LEVEL ASSESSMENT PATHWAYS (SCORED OUT OF 6 PER ENQUIRY):

EMERGING (1–2 / 6)	DEVELOPING (3–4 / 6)	SECURING (5 / 6)	GREATER DEPTH (6 / 6)
Recalls standalone historical dates, names, and basic factual definitions.	Explains cause and consequence using structured because/as a result connectives.	Demonstrates deep contextual knowledge and connects multiple historical factors.	Evaluates synoptic turning points and explains long-term causal significance.

CUMULATIVE UNIT PROGRESS TRACKER (OVERALL UNIT SCORE):

ENQUIRY 1 (/6)	ENQUIRY 2 (/6)	ENQUIRY 3 (/6)	ENQUIRY 4 (/6)	ENQUIRY 5 (/6)	TOTAL (/30)	MILESTONE ACHIEVED
[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[ ]	[/ 30]	[ ] Bronze • [ ] Silver • [ ] Gold

TEACHER COMMENDATION & FORMATIVE FEEDBACK: **EFFORT GRADE: [ ]**

Teacher Signature: _____ Date: _____